



COVER LETTER / JOB ID 41852

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Hiring Team,

Southern Glazer's does not need MLOps as a technical sidecar. The company operates a large physical distribution network, meaningful digital commerce, and a commercial model that is becoming more hybrid, digital, and data-driven. In that environment, the real product is confidence: confidence that a model is ready to release, observable in production, recoverable when conditions change, and connected to a business outcome.

That operating problem is where my experience transfers. At Compunetics, I led across engineering, manufacturing, quality, delivery, and high-reliability technical programs, building quality systems, root-cause practices, performance measures, and controls. At Amazon, I built operating visibility, escalation paths, standard work, and leadership routines in a 24/7 environment supporting approximately five million second-day orders annually. Today at Vape-Jet, I connect factory, customer, support, engineering, and machine-fleet signals into prioritized work, earlier risk detection, better handoffs, dashboards, training, and accountability in a software-enabled robotics and machine-vision environment with approximately 1,000 fielded robots.

Through DudeWorth, I also develop AI-readiness and workflow frameworks that connect value, feasibility, data readiness, evaluation, human judgment, escalation, decision records, governance, adoption burden, reuse, and time-to-value. My point of view is that governance works when it is built into how work moves.

I should address the strongest objection directly. My background is not a conventional seven-year progression through ML platform operations, and I will not rewrite it into one. If the role requires the director to be the deepest hands-on MLOps engineer in the room, I am not the obvious profile. If it requires a leader who can make reliability, ownership, governance, cross-functional decision rights, adoption, and business outcomes cohere around deep technical talent, that is a serious conversation.

My candidate thesis is a Model Reliability Contract: every production model should have explicit release evidence, live operating boundaries, named intervention rights, and a business-outcome owner. I have translated it into a Reliability Interlock, a 120-day entry plan, an interview thesis brief, and a practical one-page operating artifact.

The posting's location requirement also deserves direct resolution: I am based in Pittsburgh and this campaign does not presume relocation. I would value the chance to test the role thesis and practical constraints against Southern Glazer's actual platform organization.

Operationally, I would use the contract to align data science, data engineering, platform operations, IT/security, and business owners around consequence-tiered release evidence, a shared service envelope, intervention authority, and a recurring reliability review. Adoption would be measured as part of model health rather than left to a communications appendix.

Candidate materials: candidate vision, role-aligned resume, interview thesis brief, 120-day entry plan, and one-page Model Reliability Contract - all linked from the web version of this letter.

Carpe diem,
Russell Dudek